



BEFORE

In the 1850s, anti-Catholicism and concerns about both slavery and immigration drew Americans to new political parties.

NEW POLITICAL PARTIES

As the Whig party faded, local nativist groups organized into the anti-immigration "[Know Nothing](#)" Party. At the same time, many Northerners who advocated "[Free Soil](#)" in the West joined anti-Southern and anti-slavery coalitions that became the **Republican Party**.

SLAVE POWER

Many Northerners feared the expansion of slavery into the West. Southern political power was frequently characterized as a conspiracy or "**Slave Power**." These perceived threats to white liberties in the North mobilized popular support for the Republicans more than any moral commitment to the **abolition of slavery and justice for Black Americans** (see [The Fury of Abolition](#)).

In May 1856, three violent events—two in Washington, D.C., and one in Kansas—convinced many white Northerners that the South really did constitute a threat to their rights and liberties. The unconnected events inspired Northern enthusiasm for the Republican Party—founded just two years earlier by a coalition that included abolitionists, former anti-slavery Whigs, and former Free-Soilers—and led to a sudden surge in support for the party.

On May 8, Alabama-born Congressman Philemon Herbert, furious when he was refused service at the Willard Hotel in Washington, D.C., attacked waiter Thomas Keating, triggering a dining room melee that ended with Herbert shooting the waiter dead. The Republicans printed handbills, speeches, and pamphlets stressing enslavers' disdain for "menials" and portraying the attack as a blow against white workers and farmers. Party editors quoted inflammatory items from the Southern press as proof of the tyrannical nature of enslavers.

Two weeks later, on May 22, Senator Charles Sumner of Massachusetts was brutally beaten on the floor of the Senate by a Southern congressman, Preston Brooks. Republicans, joined by a number of former Democrats, organized "indignation meetings" that drew thousands of Northern men and women into public condemnation of the assault.